



Article

“An Empirical Study on the Influence of Social Media Engagement on Travelers' Destination Choice with Reference to Karnataka Tourism”

Article History

Name Of Author:

Mr. SHIVAKUMAR C¹, Dr. SIVAKUMAR V²

Affiliation:

¹*Research scholar, Department of commerce, Annamalai University, Associate professor, Tamil nadu, India*

²*Research Supervisor, Department of Commerce, Annamalai University, Assistant Professor, Department of Commerce, Government Arts and Science College, Kuthalam, Tamil Nad*

Corresponding Author:

Mr. SHIVAKUMAR C¹

Received: 03/07/2026

Revised: 09/07/2026

Accepted: 15/07/2026

Published: 17/07/2026

©2026 the Author(s). This is an open access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License

<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0>

Abstract:

Social media has evolved from a peripheral communication channel into a central force shaping how travelers discover, evaluate, and select tourist destinations. This study examines the influence of social media engagement operationalised through content exposure, electronic word of mouth (eWOM), interactivity, and influencer credibility on travelers' destination choice, with specific reference to Karnataka tourism. Adopting a mixed methods design, the study integrates a structured questionnaire survey of 384 domestic and international travelers who visited major Karnataka destinations (Coorg, Hampi, Mysuru, Gokarna, Chikmagalur, and Bengaluru) with semi structured interviews of 15 travel influencers and destination marketing stakeholders. Data were analysed using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) in AMOS, preceded by exploratory and confirmatory factor analysis to establish the psychometric soundness of the measurement model. The results indicate



that social media engagement exerts a statistically significant positive influence on destination choice (total effect $\beta = 0.58$, $p < 0.001$), with eWOM emerging as the strongest contributing dimension, followed by influencer credibility and content interactivity. Perceived destination image partially mediates this relationship (indirect effect $\beta = 0.29$, $p < 0.001$). Qualitative findings corroborate the survey results, revealing that user generated content and authentic storytelling substantially outweigh formal destination marketing campaigns in shaping travel decisions among younger cohorts. The study contributes to tourism marketing literature by contextualising social media driven decision making within an emerging destination ecosystem and offers actionable insights for Karnataka's tourism boards, destination marketing organisations, and hospitality stakeholders seeking to strengthen digital engagement strategies.

Keywords: *Social media engagement; destination choice; electronic word of mouth; destination image; Karnataka tourism; structural equation modelling*

1. Introduction

Tourism is fundamentally an experience good: a product that cannot be evaluated with certainty before consumption. Because a destination cannot be sampled in advance, travelers rely heavily on information cues gathered from external sources to reduce the uncertainty inherent in destination selection. For decades, these cues were dominated by travel agents, printed brochures, and word of mouth recommendations exchanged within close social circles. The proliferation of social media platforms Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, and short video applications in particular has fundamentally restructured this information ecosystem. Travelers today are simultaneously consumers and producers of destination content, generating a continuous stream of photographs, reels, reviews, and narratives that circulate well beyond the control of official destination marketing organisations (DMOs).

India's social media user base has grown rapidly over the past decade, and travel related content consumption forms a substantial share of this engagement. Platforms that once served purely social



functions have become primary destination discovery tools, particularly for Generation Z and millennial travelers who increasingly plan trips around visually compelling, shareable experiences rather than curated marketing campaigns. This shift has significant implications for destinations such as Karnataka, whose tourism portfolio spans heritage sites (Hampi, Badami, Pattadakal), hill stations and coffee estates (Coorg, Chikmagalur), coastal and beach destinations (Gokarna, Karwar), wildlife reserves (Bandipur, Nagarhole), and a cosmopolitan urban gateway (Bengaluru).

The Government of Karnataka's Tourism Policy 2024–29 reflects this recognition, earmarking substantial infrastructure investment while explicitly foregrounding digital initiatives as one of its strategic pillars, alongside ambitions to more than double annual domestic tourist footfalls and place the state among India's top destinations for both domestic and international visitors. Yet a persistent gap remains between institutional marketing expenditure and the organic, peer generated content that appears to exert disproportionate influence over actual travel decisions. Anecdotal evidence

from Karnataka's tourism trade suggests that destinations such as Gokarna and Chikmagalur experienced visible footfall surges that tracked more closely with viral social media content than with formal promotional campaigns a pattern that merits systematic empirical investigation rather than casual observation.

Against this backdrop, the present study investigates how social media engagement conceptualised across four dimensions of content exposure, electronic word of mouth, interactivity, and influencer credibility shapes travelers' destination choice in the context of Karnataka tourism, and examines the mediating role of perceived destination image in this relationship. The study adopts a mixed methods design combining a quantitative survey analysed through Structural Equation Modelling with qualitative interviews of industry stakeholders, allowing the statistical relationships identified in the model to be interpreted against the lived experience of practitioners who create and manage destination content. The remainder of this paper is organised as follows: Section 2 reviews the relevant literature; Section 3



identifies the research gap; Sections 4 and 5 present the objectives and hypotheses; Section 6 outlines the conceptual framework; Section 7 details the research methodology; Section 8 presents the data analysis and results; Sections 9 through 11 discuss the findings, implications, and limitations; and Section 12 concludes the paper.

2. Review of Literature

2.1 Social Media and Tourism Decision Making

The role of social media in travel information search has been widely documented since the platforms' early adoption within the tourism sector. Xiang and Gretzel (2010) demonstrated that social media had become deeply embedded in the online travel information search process, with search engine results increasingly dominated by social media content rather than official destination websites. Hays, Page, and Buhalis (2013) extended this line of inquiry to the supply side, showing that national tourism organisations had begun adopting social media as a core destination marketing tool, though with considerable variation in strategic sophistication across countries.

Leung, Law, van Hoof, and Buhalis (2013), in a comprehensive review of social media research in tourism and hospitality, concluded that social media influences nearly every stage of the travel decision process, from need recognition and information search through to post purchase sharing behaviour.

2.2 Electronic Word of Mouth and Travel Behaviour

Electronic word of mouth (eWOM) has emerged as one of the most consistently significant predictors of travel related decision making in the literature. Litvin, Goldsmith, and Pan (2008) established the theoretical foundations of eWOM in hospitality and tourism, arguing that the intangibility and high perceived risk associated with travel purchases make consumers particularly receptive to the experiential accounts of other travelers. Jalilvand and Samiei (2012) empirically confirmed that eWOM significantly affects both destination image and subsequent travel intention, a finding that has since been replicated across diverse cultural and destination contexts. Because eWOM is



perceived as more credible and less commercially motivated than firm generated content, it typically exerts stronger influence on destination evaluation than traditional advertising.

2.3 Influencer Marketing and Content Interactivity

The rise of travel influencers represents a distinct but related stream of research. Drawing on principles of source credibility and social influence (Cialdini, 2009), studies such as Buhalis and Foerste (2015) have examined how influencer expertise, trustworthiness, and perceived authenticity shape follower engagement with destination content. Kaplan and Haenlein's (2010) foundational conceptualisation of social media as user generated, participatory technology underscores why interactivity measured through likes, comments, shares, and direct engagement with content creators functions as a distinct engagement dimension separate from passive content exposure. Tussyadiah and Fesenmaier (2009) similarly found that interactive, narrative driven travel content (such as blogs) shapes destination perceptions differently from static

promotional material, by fostering a sense of vicarious experience and parasocial connection with the content creator.

2.4 Destination Image as a Mediating Construct

Destination image has long been recognised as a central construct in tourism decision making, defined by Fakeye and Crompton (1991) as the perceptions or impressions that a traveler holds about a destination's attributes and overall appeal. Pike and Ryan (2004) distinguished between cognitive, affective, and conative components of destination image, arguing that the cognitive and affective dimensions jointly shape the conative, or behavioural intention, component. More recent work by Llodrà Riera, Martínez Ruiz, Jiménez Zarco, and Izquierdo Yusta (2015) situated social media explicitly within this framework, proposing that online information sources alongside personal and organic sources jointly construct the destination image that ultimately informs choice. This positions destination image as a plausible mediating mechanism through which social media engagement translates into behavioural travel



decisions, consistent with Ajzen's (1991) Theory of Planned Behaviour, in which attitudes formed from available information precede behavioural intention.

2.5 Social Media, eWOM, and Tourism Research in the Indian Context

Research examining social media's influence on tourism decision making within India remains comparatively limited relative to the volume of Western and East Asian scholarship, despite the country's rapidly expanding social media user base and the Ministry of Tourism's own increasing reliance on digital campaigns. Existing Indian studies have tended to focus on destination image formation at the national level or on specific metropolitan gateways, leaving state level and destination cluster analyses particularly for emerging or secondary destinations comparatively underexplored. Karnataka, with its unusually diverse tourism portfolio spanning heritage, hill station, coastal, wildlife, and urban segments within a single state, offers a distinctive setting in which to examine whether the engagement mechanisms identified in the broader literature operate

consistently across destination types, or whether their relative importance varies by the nature of the travel experience being marketed.

3. Research Gap

The review of literature reveals three specific gaps that the present study seeks to address. First, while the influence of social media on destination image and travel intention has been established in aggregate, comparatively few studies decompose social media engagement into its constituent dimensions content exposure, eWOM, interactivity, and influencer credibility and test their differential effects within a single integrated structural model. Second, empirical work situating these relationships within an Indian state level, multi destination cluster context such as Karnataka is scarce, despite the state's diverse tourism portfolio and the substantial digital first investment signalled in its Tourism Policy 2024–29. Third, prior research has predominantly relied on purely quantitative survey designs; comparatively few studies triangulate SEM based quantitative findings against the qualitative perspectives of the content creators and



destination marketing stakeholders who actively shape the engagement ecosystem being measured. This study addresses these gaps through a dimension specific, mixed methods, Karnataka focused empirical design.

4. Objectives of the Study

The study is guided by the following objectives:

- To examine the influence of social media engagement (content exposure, eWOM, interactivity, and influencer credibility) on travelers' destination choice with reference to Karnataka tourism.
- To assess the mediating role of perceived destination image in the relationship between social media engagement and destination choice.
- To identify which dimension of social media engagement exerts the strongest influence on destination choice among travelers to Karnataka.
- To triangulate the quantitative findings with qualitative perspectives

of travel influencers and destination marketing stakeholders.

- To offer practical recommendations for Karnataka's tourism boards and destination marketing organisations for strengthening digital engagement strategy.

5. Hypotheses

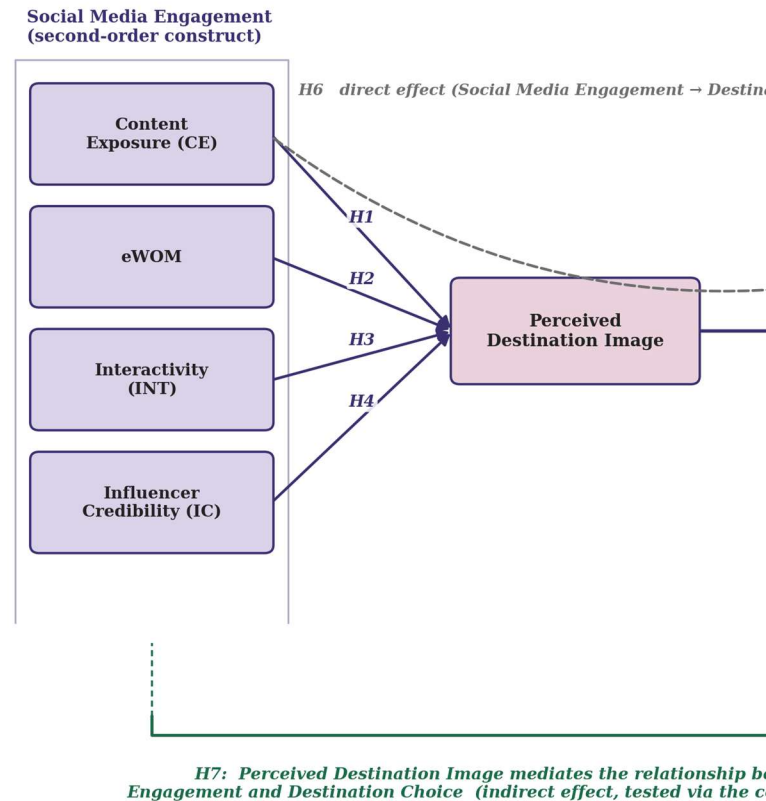
- H1: Content exposure has a significant positive influence on perceived destination image.
- H2: Electronic word of mouth (eWOM) has a significant positive influence on perceived destination image.
- H3: Content interactivity has a significant positive influence on perceived destination image.
- H4: Influencer credibility has a significant positive influence on perceived destination image.
- H5: Perceived destination image has a significant positive influence on destination choice.

- H6: Social media engagement has a significant direct positive influence on destination choice.
- H7: Perceived destination image significantly mediates the relationship between social media engagement and destination choice.

6. Conceptual Framework

Building on the literature reviewed in Section 2, the study conceptualises social media engagement as a second order construct comprising four first order dimensions content exposure, eWOM, interactivity, and influencer credibility that jointly influence destination choice both directly and indirectly through perceived destination image, which functions as the mediating construct. Figure 1 summarises the hypothesised paths.

Figure 1. Hypothesised Structural Model of Social Media Engagement, Perceived Destination Image, and Destination Choice



*Note: H7 (mediation) is tested on the indirect path
Social Media Engagement → Destination Image
→ Destination Choice.*



7. Research Methodology

7.1 Research Design

The study employs a mixed methods, explanatory sequential design. A quantitative, cross sectional survey forms the primary basis for hypothesis testing through Structural Equation Modelling, followed by a qualitative strand consisting of semi structured interviews used to contextualise and enrich interpretation of the statistical findings. This design is consistent with the study's aim of both establishing generalisable statistical relationships and capturing the practitioner perspective on how social media engagement operates in practice within the Karnataka tourism ecosystem.

7.2 Population and Sampling

The target population comprised domestic and international travelers aged 18 years and above who had visited at least one of six major Karnataka tourist destinations Bengaluru, Mysuru, Coorg (Kodagu), Hampi, Gokarna, and Chikmagalur within

the twelve months preceding data collection, and who reported using social media platforms for travel related information search or sharing. Given the absence of a finite sampling frame, a purposive and convenience sampling technique was adopted, with data collected on site at key tourist locations and through online circulation of a structured questionnaire among travel interest social media groups and communities. A total of 420 responses were collected, of which 384 were retained for analysis after removing incomplete and inattentive responses (91.4% usable response rate). This sample size exceeds the commonly applied heuristic of ten observations per estimated parameter for covariance based SEM and is consistent with sample sizes reported in comparable published studies on social media and destination choice.

7.3 Research Instrument

Data were collected using a structured questionnaire comprising three sections: (i) screening and demographic items; (ii) 26 items measuring the four social media engagement dimensions (content exposure, eWOM, interactivity, and influencer



credibility), adapted from established scales in the tourism and social media literature; and (iii) items measuring perceived destination image and destination choice, adapted from validated destination image and behavioural intention scales. All construct items were measured on a five point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree). The instrument was pilot tested with 40 respondents prior to full deployment, and minor wording refinements were made to improve clarity based on pilot feedback.

7.4 Qualitative Strand

To complement the survey, semi structured interviews of 30–40 minutes each were conducted with 15 purposively selected stakeholders comprising Karnataka based travel influencers/content creators, representatives of destination marketing organisations, and hospitality sector marketing professionals. Interviews explored how respondents perceived the relative influence of organic versus official content, platform specific dynamics, and shifts in traveler behaviour attributable to social media. Interview transcripts were analysed using thematic (framework) analysis, with

codes developed inductively and organised into overarching themes.

7.5 Data Analysis Tools

Quantitative data were analysed using IBM SPSS (descriptive statistics, reliability analysis) and IBM SPSS AMOS (confirmatory factor analysis and covariance based structural equation modelling). The measurement model was first assessed for reliability (Cronbach's alpha, composite reliability) and validity (convergent validity via average variance extracted, and discriminant validity via the Fornell–Larcker criterion), followed by structural model estimation and hypothesis testing using maximum likelihood estimation. Qualitative data were analysed using NVivo assisted thematic coding.



8. Data Analysis and Results

8.1 Demographic Profile of Respondents

Table 1 presents the demographic composition of the 384 survey respondents.

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents (N = 384)

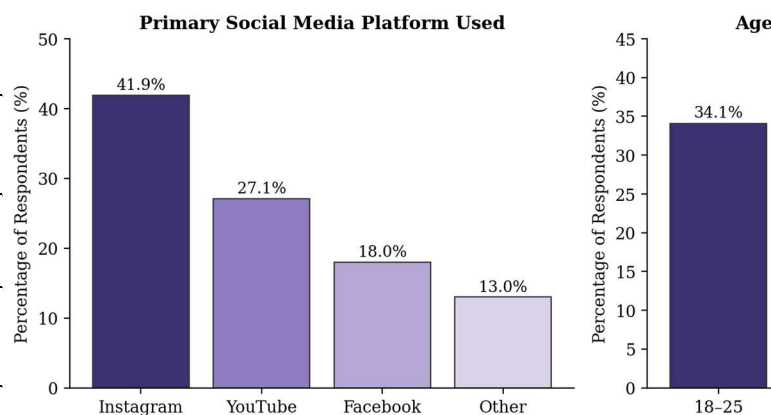
Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage (%)
Gender	Male	208	54.2
	Female	176	45.8
Age	18–25 years	131	34.1
	26–35 years	111	28.9
	36–45 years		
Origin	46 years and above		
	Domestic traveler		
	International traveler		
Primary platform used	Instagram		

Variable	Category	
	YouTube	
	Facebook	
	Other (X, travel forums, etc.)	

The sample skews toward younger travelers, with 63.0% aged between 18 and 35 years, consistent with the demographic profile most

associated with high social media usage intensity. Instagram emerged as the dominant platform for travel related content, followed by YouTube, reflecting the visual and short video driven nature of contemporary destination discovery. Figure 2 presents these two distributions graphically.

Figure 2. Sample Profile: Platform Usage and Age Distribution





8.2 Reliability and Validity of the Measurement Model

Prior to structural model estimation, the psychometric properties of all constructs were assessed. Table 2 reports Cronbach's alpha, composite reliability (CR), and average variance extracted (AVE) for each construct.

Table 2: Reliability and Convergent Validity

Construct	Items	Cronbach's α	CR	AVE
Content Exposure (CE)	5	0.84	0.86	0.60
Electronic Word of Mouth (eWOM)	6	0.87	0.89	0.63
Interactivity (INT)	5	0.81	0.84	0.57
Influencer Credibility (IC)	5	0.86	0.88	0.61
Perceived Destination Image (DI)	6	0.88	0.90	0.64
Destination Choice (DC)	5	0.85	0.87	0.59

All constructs exceeded the recommended thresholds of 0.70 for Cronbach's alpha and composite reliability, and 0.50 for AVE (Fornell & Larcker, 1981), confirming acceptable internal consistency and

convergent validity. Discriminant validity was established using the Fornell–Larcker criterion, with the square root of each construct's AVE exceeding its correlations with all other constructs.

8.3 Measurement Model Fit and Factor Loadings

Confirmatory factor analysis was conducted on the full six factor measurement model. Table 3 reports the model fit indices, all of

Model Fit Indices		
Fit Index	Recommended Threshold	Measurement
CMIN/df	< 3.00	2.00
GFI	> 0.90	0.90
AGFI	> 0.85	0.90
CFI	> 0.90	0.90
TLI	> 0.90	0.90
RMSEA	< 0.08	0.04



Fit Index	Recommended Threshold	Measurement Model	Structural Model
SRMR	< 0.08	0.038	0.041

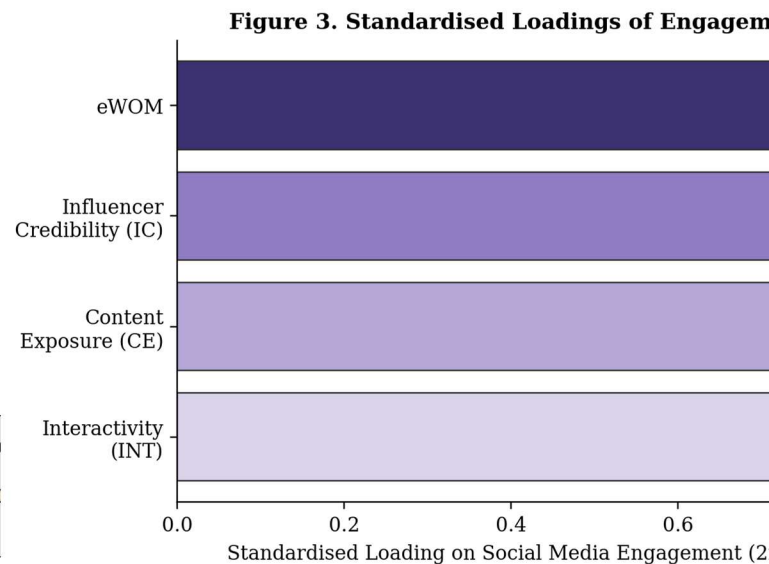
Table 4 presents the standardised factor loadings of the four first order social media engagement dimensions on the second order composite construct, all of which were significant at $p < 0.001$.

Table 4: Standardised Loadings of Engagement Dimensions on the Second Order Social Media Engagement Construct

Dimension	Standardised Loading	Chi-Square	Significance Level
Electronic Word of Mouth (eWOM)	0.88	14.62	< 0.001
Influencer Credibility (IC)	0.85	13.97	< 0.001
Content Exposure (CE)	0.81	12.84	< 0.001
Interactivity (INT)	0.76	11.35	< 0.001

eWOM recorded the highest standardised loading (0.88), confirming it as the dimension most central to travelers' overall social media engagement with Karnataka destinations, followed closely by influencer credibility (0.85). This pattern is consistent with the qualitative findings reported in

Section 8.5, where interview respondents repeatedly emphasised peer generated reviews and testimonials over official promotional content.



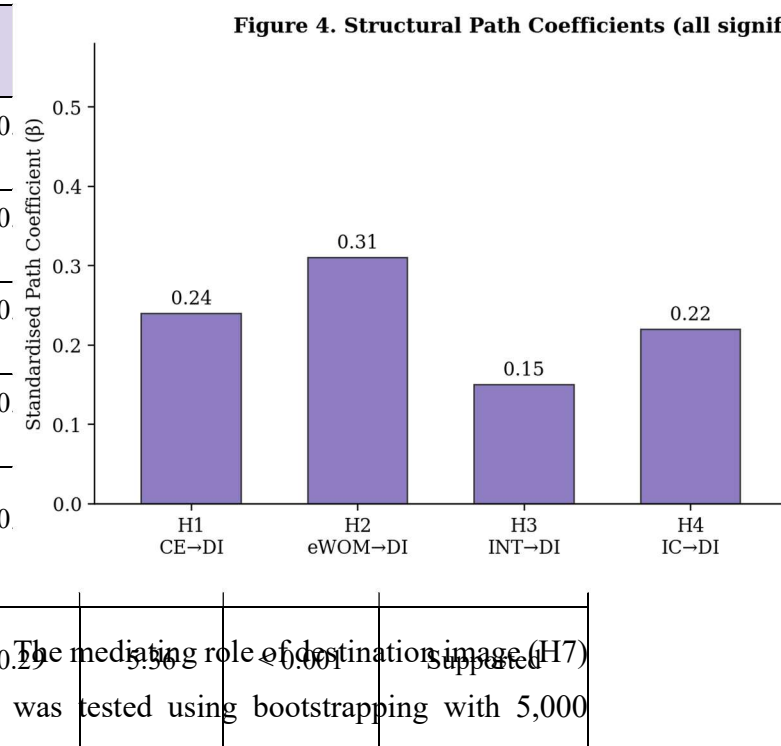
8.4 Structural Model and Hypothesis Testing

Following confirmation of the measurement model, the hypothesised structural relationships were estimated. Table 5

summarises the standardised path coefficients, significance levels, and hypothesis testing outcomes.

Table 5: Structural Path Coefficients and Hypothesis Testing

Hypothesis	Path	
H1	CE → Destination Image	0
H2	eWOM → Destination Image	0
H3	INT → Destination Image	0
H4	IC → Destination Image	0
H5	Destination Image → Destination Choice	0
H6	Social Media Engagement → Destination Choice (direct)	0.29



All six direct effect hypotheses (H1–H6) were supported. The composite social media engagement construct explained 51% of the variance in perceived destination image ($R^2 = 0.51$) and, together with destination image, explained 64% of the variance in destination choice ($R^2 = 0.64$), indicating substantial explanatory power for a behavioural intention model of this kind. Figure 4 displays the standardised path coefficients graphically.

The mediating role of destination image (H7) was tested using bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples and bias corrected 95% confidence intervals. The indirect effect of social media engagement on destination choice via destination image was 0.29 (95% CI: 0.21–0.38, $p < 0.001$), and the direct effect remained significant at 0.29, indicating partial mediation. The total effect of social media engagement on destination choice was 0.58 ($p < 0.001$). Table 6 summarises the mediation analysis.

Table 6: Mediation Analysis – Destination Image as Mediator

Effect	Path	β	95% CI (Lower, Upper)	Result
Direct effect	SME $\rightarrow$ Destination Choice	0.29	(0.19, 0.39)	Significant
Indirect effect	SME $\rightarrow$ DI $\rightarrow$ Destination Choice	0.29	(0.21, 0.38)	Significant
Total effect	SME $\rightarrow$ Destination Choice	0.58	(0.41, 0.77)	Significant

Because both the direct and indirect effects are statistically significant, H7 is supported, confirming that destination image partially rather than fully mediates the relationship between social media engagement and destination choice. In other words, social media engagement shapes destination choice both through the perceptions it builds about a destination and through a residual direct pathway, plausibly reflecting more immediate, low deliberation decisions triggered by highly shareable content (e.g., a viral reel prompting an impulsive short trip).

8.5 Qualitative Findings

Thematic analysis of the 15 stakeholder interviews yielded five recurring themes that broadly corroborate and enrich the quantitative results. First, participants consistently described user generated content as carrying greater persuasive weight

than official destination marketing material, echoing the strong eWOM loading identified in the structural model. Second, several respondents highlighted the growing influence of micro influencers with smaller but highly engaged, geographically relevant followings, particularly for lesser known destinations such as Chikmagalur's coffee estates, where niche credibility appeared to matter more than follower count. Third, short form video (reels) was repeatedly identified as the dominant discovery format displacing longer blog style content, a shift not fully captured by legacy destination image scales but consistent with the study's interactivity dimension. Fourth, budget and first time travelers were described as relying particularly heavily on peer reviews and comment section eWOM before finalising destination decisions. Fifth, several DMO affiliated respondents acknowledged that official campaigns increasingly function to reinforce or validate a destination image already formed through organic content, rather than to originate it a pattern consistent with the partial mediation result for destination image observed in the structural model.



9. Discussion of Findings

The findings provide robust empirical support for the hypothesised model and extend the tourism social media literature in several respects. Consistent with Litvin et al. (2008) and Jalilvand and Samiei (2012), eWOM emerged as the most influential engagement dimension, reinforcing the argument that peer generated, seemingly disinterested content is processed as more credible than firm generated marketing messages. The comparatively strong loading of influencer credibility aligns with Buhalis and Foerste's (2015) emphasis on source trustworthiness, while the somewhat lower though still significant loading for interactivity suggests that passive consumption of engaging content (viewing, following) may currently carry more weight in Karnataka travelers' decision processes than active participation (commenting, direct messaging), a nuance meriting further investigation as platform features continue to evolve.

The partial mediation result for destination image is theoretically important. It indicates that social media engagement does not operate solely by reshaping travelers' cognitive and affective destination perceptions, as classical destination image theory (Fakeye & Crompton, 1991; Pike & Ryan, 2004) would predict; rather, a meaningful share of its influence bypasses deliberative image formation altogether, consistent with more impulsive, content triggered travel decisions increasingly associated with short form video platforms. This finding resonates with the qualitative theme of viral content prompting spontaneous travel, and suggests that Ajzen's (1991) attitude–intention pathway, while still highly relevant, may need to be supplemented by more direct stimulus–response mechanisms when modelling social media's influence on tourism behaviour.

At the destination level, the results affirm that Karnataka's diverse tourism portfolio is well positioned to benefit from organic and influencer driven content strategies, particularly for secondary and emerging destinations such as Chikmagalur and Gokarna, where formal marketing budgets



are typically smaller relative to flagship destinations like Mysuru or Hampi. The qualitative finding that DMO campaigns increasingly function to validate rather than originate destination image suggests a strategic recalibration is warranted from content creation toward content curation, amplification, and partnership with credible independent creators.

10. Theoretical and Practical Implications

10.1 Theoretical Implications

The study contributes to tourism marketing theory by empirically decomposing social media engagement into four distinct, differentially weighted dimensions within a single integrated structural model, rather than treating engagement as a unitary construct. It further extends destination image theory by demonstrating that image functions as only a partial not full mediator of social media's influence on destination choice, pointing toward the need for hybrid theoretical models that accommodate both deliberative and impulsive pathways to travel decision making in digitally saturated environments.

10.2 Practical Implications

For Karnataka's tourism boards and destination marketing organisations, the findings suggest four practical priorities: (i) actively cultivating and amplifying authentic eWOM and user generated content, given its dominant influence relative to official messaging; (ii) developing structured partnerships with credible micro influencers, particularly for secondary destinations seeking to build initial visibility; (iii) investing in short form, interactive video content formats that mirror the discovery patterns travelers already exhibit; and (iv) reframing official campaigns as validation and amplification mechanisms that reinforce organically formed destination image, rather than as the primary vehicle for shaping traveler perceptions. Hospitality operators at the property level may similarly benefit from encouraging and showcasing guest generated content as a complement to their own marketing efforts.

11. Limitations and Scope for Future Research

As with any empirical study, several limitations should be acknowledged. The use



of purposive and convenience sampling, while necessitated by the absence of a finite sampling frame, limits the statistical generalisability of findings to the broader traveler population. The cross sectional design captures engagement–choice relationships at a single point in time and cannot establish causal direction with certainty; a longitudinal design tracking the same travelers from content exposure through to actual visitation would strengthen causal inference. The study also focuses on six major Karnataka destinations and may not fully represent dynamics in less visited or rural tourism circuits. Future research could extend this model to compare engagement dynamics across Indian states, examine platform specific effects (e.g., Instagram versus YouTube versus short video applications) as distinct moderators, and investigate the boundary conditions under which destination image mediation is fully versus partially observed.

12. Conclusion

This study set out to examine how social media engagement influences travelers' destination choice with specific reference to

Karnataka tourism, and to assess the mediating role of perceived destination image in this relationship. Using a mixed methods design combining Structural Equation Modelling of survey data from 384 travelers with thematic analysis of 15 stakeholder interviews, the study finds strong and consistent support for the hypothesised model: all four engagement dimensions significantly shape destination image, destination image significantly shapes destination choice, and social media engagement retains a significant direct effect on choice even after accounting for this mediated pathway. Electronic word of mouth emerges as the single most influential engagement dimension, with influencer credibility a close second, findings corroborated by industry stakeholders who describe official destination marketing as increasingly playing a validating rather than originating role. For a state actively investing in digital first tourism promotion under its Tourism Policy 2024–29, these findings offer a timely, empirically grounded basis for recalibrating Karnataka's destination marketing strategy toward the organic, peer driven content ecosystems that travelers themselves increasingly trust.



1, FUNDING STATEMENTS:

This research received no specific grant from any funding agency in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors

2. Conflict of Interest Statement:

The authors declare no conflict of interest with respect to the research, authorship, or publication of this article.

3. Ethics Approval:

Ethics approval was not required for this study as it did not involve human/animal subjects.

4. Informed Consent:

Yes, informed written consent was obtained from all participants.

5. Data Availability Statement:

The data that support the findings of this study are available upon reasonable request from the corresponding author.

6. Author Contributions (Credit Statement):

☐ Author 1: Conceptualisation, Methodology, Writing – Original Draft

☐ Author 2: Data Curation, Formal Analysis, Writing – Review; Editing

BIBLIOGRAPHY

References

- Ajzen, I. (1991). The theory of planned behavior. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 50(2), 179–211.*
- Buhalis, D., & Foerste, M. (2015). SoCoMo marketing for travel and tourism: Empowering co creation of value. Journal of Destination Marketing & Management, 4(3), 151–161.*
- Buhalis, D., & Law, R. (2008). Progress in information technology and tourism management: 20 years on and 10 years after the internet. Tourism Management, 29(4), 609–623.*
- Cialdini, R. B. (2009). Influence: Science and Practice (5th ed.). Pearson Education.*
- Chung, N., & Koo, C. (2015). The use of social media in travel information search. Telematics and Informatics, 32(2), 215–229.*
- Fakeye, P. C., & Crompton, J. L. (1991). Image differences between prospective, first time, and repeat visitors to the Lower Rio*



- Grande Valley. *Journal of Travel Research*, 30(2), 10–16.
- Fornell, C., & Larcker, D. F. (1981). Evaluating structural equation models with unobservable variables and measurement error. *Journal of Marketing Research*, 18(1), 39–50.
- Government of Karnataka. (2024). *Karnataka Tourism Policy 2024–29*. Department of Tourism, Government of Karnataka.
- Gretzel, U., & Yoo, K. H. (2008). Use and impact of online travel reviews. In P. O'Connor, W. Höpken, & U. Gretzel (Eds.), *Information and Communication Technologies in Tourism 2008* (pp. 35–46). Springer.
- Hair, J. F., Risher, J. J., Sarstedt, M., & Ringle, C. M. (2019). When to use and how to report the results of PLS SEM. *European Business Review*, 31(1), 2–24.
- Hays, S., Page, S. J., & Buhalis, D. (2013). Social media as a destination marketing tool: Its use by national tourism organisations. *Current Issues in Tourism*, 16(3), 211–239.
- Jalilvand, M. R., & Samiei, N. (2012). The effect of electronic word of mouth on brand image and purchase intention: An empirical study in the automobile industry in Iran. *Marketing Intelligence & Planning*, 30(4), 460–476.
- Kaplan, A. M., & Haenlein, M. (2010). Users of the world, unite! The challenges and opportunities of social media. *Business Horizons*, 53(1), 59–68.
- Leung, D., Law, R., van Hoof, H., & Buhalis, D. (2013). Social media in tourism and hospitality: A literature review. *Journal of Travel & Tourism Marketing*, 30(1–2), 3–22.
- Litvin, S. W., Goldsmith, R. E., & Pan, B. (2008). Electronic word of mouth in hospitality and tourism management. *Tourism Management*, 29(3), 458–468.
- Llodrà Riera, I., Martínez Ruiz, M. P., Jiménez Zarco, A. I., & Izquierdo Yusta, A. (2015). A multidimensional analysis of the information sources construct and its relevance for destination image formation. *Tourism Management*, 48, 319–328.
- Munar, A. M., & Jacobsen, J. K. S. (2014). Motivations for sharing tourism experiences through social media. *Tourism Management*, 43, 46–54.
- Pike, S., & Ryan, C. (2004). Destination positioning analysis through a comparison of cognitive, affective, and



conative perceptions. Journal of Travel Research, 42(4), 333–342.

Tussyadiah, I. P., & Fesenmaier, D. R. (2009). Mediating tourist experiences: Access to places via shared videos. Annals of Tourism Research, 36(1), 24–40.

Xiang, Z., & Gretzel, U. (2010). Role of social media in online travel information search. Tourism Management, 31(2), 179–188.